AIDaS Seed Grant Program

Call for Proposals

2026-2027 AIDaS Seed Grant Program

Milestone	Date
RFP released	August 26, 2026
Proposal deadline	October 16, 2026, 11:59 p.m. ET
Funding notification	December 16, 2026
Anticipated project start	January 1, 2027

Overview

The Institute for AI and Data Science (AIDaS) at Wayne State University invites proposals for its 2026–2027 Seed Grant Program (AIDaS SEED). The program is designed to catalyze innovative, high-impact AI research across campus, build interdisciplinary teams, and position Wayne State investigators to compete successfully for external federal funding.

Awards support early-stage projects that generate the preliminary results, prototypes, datasets, or partnerships needed to anchor competitive proposals to federal sponsors such as NSF, NIH, DOE, DOD, and the Department of Education/IES.

AIDaS anticipates making four awards of $10,000–$20,000 each for a one-year project period.

Strategic Priority Areas

Proposals must address at least one of the following four strategic areas:

1. **Foundational AI.** Core advances in machine learning and AI methodology, including large language and multimodal models, reasoning and agentic systems, trustworthy and interpretable AI, AI safety, security, and privacy, and efficient, scalable learning and inference. Work in this area should push the frontier of AI capability, reliability, or understanding rather than apply existing methods to a new domain.
2. **AI for Science.** AI-enabled acceleration of scientific discovery across disciplines such as materials, chemistry, biology and genomics, physics, environment and climate, and engineering. This includes scientific foundation models, AI-driven simulation and experimental design, and the integration of AI with high-performance computing, instrumentation, and large scientific datasets.
3. **AI for Education and Workforce Training.** AI to improve learning, teaching, and training outcomes, including intelligent tutoring and personalized learning, learning analytics, AI literacy and curriculum innovation, and AI-enabled upskilling and reskilling. Proposals that prepare students and Michigan's workforce for an AI-driven economy are especially welcome.
4. **AI for Health.** AI for biomedical discovery and healthcare delivery, including clinical decision support, medical imaging and diagnostics, biomedical and health informatics, population and public health analytics, and drug discovery. Proposals should attend to trustworthy, equitable, and clinically meaningful deployment of AI in health settings.

Alignment with National Priorities

AIDaS strongly encourages proposals that align with national priorities specified in current U.S. science and technology policy, including priorities articulated by the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy (OSTP) and reflected in the national AI strategy and federal agency investment roadmaps (e.g., NSF's AI portfolio and National AI Research Institutes, NIH AI/data science initiatives, and DOE and DOD AI programs). Each proposal should briefly articulate how the proposed work advances these national priorities and connects to specific federal programs and solicitations.

Priority for New Investigators

Special priority will be given to proposals led by New Investigators — particularly tenure-track Assistant Professors — who demonstrate alignment with a clear federal funding landscape. Competitive New Investigator proposals will identify one or more specific target funding opportunities (e.g., NSF core or CAREER programs, NIH R-series mechanisms, DOD young investigator programs) and present a credible plan and timeline for submitting an external proposal following the seed award.

Eligibility

The PI must be an affiliated member of AIDaS and hold a tenure-track/tenured faculty appointment at Wayne State University. Faculty who are not yet AIDaS members may request affiliation prior to submission. Co-PIs and collaborators from any WSU school or college are welcome. External collaborators from industry, healthcare systems, K-12, or community organizations may participate but may not receive award funds. Faculty may serve as PI on only one proposal per cycle.

Proposal Requirements

Submit a single PDF containing the following components:

1. **Cover page** (1 page): project title, strategic area(s) addressed, PI and co-PI names, departments and colleges, contact information, and New Investigator status.
2. **Project narrative** (3 pages): significance and innovation, approach and any preliminary

work, and expected outcomes and deliverables within the award period.

3. **AIDaS funding priority alignment** (1 page): the target agency, program(s), and solicitation(s); relevance of the proposed work to national science and technology priorities; and a timeline for external proposal submission.
4. **Budget and justification** (1 page): allowable costs include graduate student support, computing cost, invited collaborator travel cost, and data management/storage.
5. **Biosketches** (2 pages per investigator, NSF or NIH format).

Review Criteria

Proposals will be evaluated by a faculty review panel convened by AIDaS using the following criteria:

- **Intellectual merit and innovation:** the significance of the problem and the originality and rigor of the proposed approach.
- **Strategic and national alignment:** fit with the four AIDaS strategic areas and alignment with national priorities specified by U.S. science and technology policy.
- **Pathway to external funding:** the likelihood that the seed project will lead to a competitive federal proposal, including a clearly identified funding target and submission timeline.
- **Team and leadership:** qualifications of the team, interdisciplinarity, and New Investigator leadership — particularly by tenure-track Assistant Professors — which receives priority consideration.
- **Feasibility:** a realistic scope, timeline, and budget for the award period.

Award Expectations

Awardees will be expected to submit a brief final report, present at an AIDaS symposium or seminar, acknowledge AIDaS support in resulting publications and proposals, and submit at least one external federal proposal within 12 months of the project end date.

Submission and Contact

Proposals must be submitted as a single PDF aidas@wayne.edu by **11:59 p.m. ET on October 16, 2026**. Questions about the program or this solicitation may be directed to aidas@wayne.edu (mailto:aidas@wayne.edu) .

Institute for AI and Data Science

For more information, contact:

Hengguang Li, co-director (mailto:[redacted])
Dongxiao Zhu, co-director (mailto:[redacted])

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